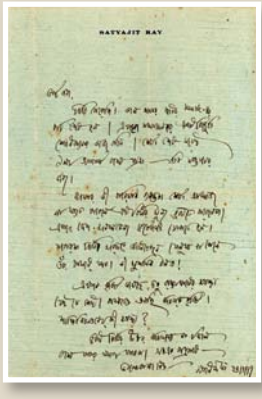
Photos courtesy MUSUI ART FOUNDATION







RAY OF GOLDEN SUN
(Left) Satyajit Ray at work, (top left) an illustration for the cover of *Sandesh*, and a letter to Nilanjana

EXHIBITION

DOWN TO THE LETTER

DISPLAYED AT AN EXHIBITION IN KOLKATA, **SATYAJIT RAY'S** LETTERS TO A YOUNG FRIEND MAKE HIS WARMTH CONSPICUOUS

Part of the tributes and events in Satyajit Ray's centenary year, *Iti, Satyajit Da: Letters to a Friend from Satyajit Ray* (on display at the Kolkata Centre for Creativity until June 7) makes for an engrossing visit. Curator K.S. Radhakrishnan assumes that most visitors will be thoroughly familiar with Ray's films and his multi-faceted output as graphic designer, writer, publisher and music composer. There are, therefore, no hagiographic panels explaining who Ray was or how he was one of the great directors of world cinema.

As we enter, we are greeted by clusters of photographs. While many are familiar with the work of Nemai Ghosh, here you can see Ray portrayed by other photographers as well. We see the director shooting on location or on the sets in Tollygunge. Some show Ray in his study, reading, writing, speaking. Yet other photos are lit by the harsh glare of flash: Ray with the good and the great of the film world—Raj Kapoor, Dilip Kumar, Uttam Kumar, Sharmila Tagore, Tapan Sinha and Mrinal Sen. Displayed also are posters that Ray designed for his films, covers for his children's magazine *Sandesh*, and reproductions of some filming notebooks. All of these circle around the core of the exhibition—a set of letters Ray wrote to Nilanjana Sen (later Chakraborty) between 1972 and 1988.

Ray's letters show a famous, busy man who had the energy to write to a young person for pleasure

Ray meets the young student in Shantiniketan when shooting *Ashani Sanket* (*Distant Thunder*). Nilanjana, only a couple of years older than Ray's son Sandip, strikes up a friendship with the director and the two write to each other regularly over the next 16 years. We don't see any of Nilanjana's letters but presented in double-sided glass frames are letters Ray writes to her in the middle of a packed and hectic work life. Ray's exquisite handwriting, mostly Bangla with the occasional English word or phrase, traverses various kinds of stationery.

Even in the one-sided epistolary exhibit, you can see this famous and busy man taking time out to reply as if to a daughter. The letters

Centenary Salute

Recent films that have doffed their hats to Satyajit Ray

ABHIJAAN (2021)

Filmmaker Qaushiq Mukherjee (known to his audiences as Q) always preferred Ray's calligraphy to his cinema, but despite the great dislike, he readily agreed to play Ray in this Soumitra Chatterjee biopic.



APARAJITO (2022)

In his film about how Ray's iconic *Pather Panchali* (1995) was made, Anik Datta changes all names—Satyajit becomes Aparajito—but he ensures that Jeetu Kamal's impersonation of Ray is eerily faithful.



